

SENATE BILL 1096

By Hensley

AN ACT to amend Tennessee Code Annotated, Title 49
and Title 68, Chapter 120, relative to places of
worship used for educational purposes.

BE IT ENACTED BY THE GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE:

SECTION 1. Tennessee Code Annotated, Section 68-120-101, is amended by adding
the following as a new subsection:

(l)

(1) For purposes of this subsection (l), "place of worship" means a
structure primarily used for religious worship and associated activities.

(2) Notwithstanding another law to the contrary:

(A) An existing place of worship may be used for educational
purposes without reclassification of the building's occupancy type;
provided that:

(i) The building complies with the safety upgrade
requirements specified in subdivision (l)(3); and

(ii) The educational use does not exceed the existing
occupancy load as determined by the local fire marshal.

(3) An existing place of worship used for educational purposes must
meet the following fire safety upgrade requirements:

(A) Smoke detectors must be:

(i) Installed in all classrooms, corridors, and common
areas;

(ii) Interconnected to activate simultaneously; and

(iii) Hardwired to the building's electrical system with battery backup;

(B) Audible alarms must meet or exceed the decibel levels required by the building and fire safety codes adopted by the state fire marshal;

(C) Strobe alarms must be installed in classrooms, assembly areas, and common areas to ensure alerting of hearing-impaired individuals;

(D) Emergency exits must be clearly marked, unobstructed, and in compliance with applicable state and local egress standards; and

(E) Fire extinguishers must be provided and maintained as required by local fire codes, with at least one (1) extinguisher on each floor and in each high-risk area such as a kitchen.

(4) A place of worship used for educational purposes that complies with this subsection *(f)* is exempt from requirements for automatic fire sprinkler systems.

SECTION 2. This act takes effect July 1, 2025, the public welfare requiring it.